FOR PART-TIME WEDDING PHOTOGRAPHERS

The Booking Pack

The DM scripts, enquiry sequence, proposal and objection replies that take a couple from first message to booked. Written for photographers with a day job who are tired of being ghosted.

Norman Yap

First edition, N

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Anything in [square brackets] is yours to change. Lines marked PERSONAL are where you write one real sentence about the couple in front of you. Nothing here carries a price. The checkout price of this pack is the only number I set, and the price of your

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DM-to-Booking scripts

Instagram and Facebook replies that take a couple from their first message to a booked call.

Most of my enquiries now start in the DMs. For a long time I treated them like emails. Long replies, a price list, a link, then nothing. What changed my bookings was a handful of habits and a shape for the conversation. The scripts below show the shape. They are not for pasting. The moment a couple feels they are talking to a template, you have lost them.

Anything in [square brackets] is yours to change. If a line could be sent to any couple without changing a word, rewrite it until it could not.

The habits that do the work

Reply while they are still on the app. If they messaged five minutes ago they are probably still scrolling. Catch them then. But reply at a human pace. A perfect answer two seconds after they hit send reads as a bot. Four hours later reads as indifference. Aim for the speed of a person who is glad to hear from them.

Two bubbles, at most. One reply is one or two messages, each a line or two. Three in a row is a wall. If you have written three, cut the one where you are explaining yourself.

One question per message. Answer what they asked first, then ask one thing they have not already told you. Never ask for something they gave you two messages ago.

Mention something they said. Their venue, their date, the way they described the day. This is the whole difference between a reply and a template.

No prices in chat. A number in a DM has no context. The couple lines it up against every other number they have been sent and you become a row on a spreadsheet. My reason is simple and true: I do not have set packages, because every wedding is different, so the chat is how I work out what suits them. If you do have set packages, your reason is different. Write it in one sentence before you use these scripts. Something like: my collections start at different points depending on how the day runs, so I would rather hear about yours first.

Call it a chat. Not a phone call, not a consultation, never a discovery call. A quick 15 minute chat is something you say yes to on a lunch break. A consultation sounds like you are about to be sold to.

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Check every calendar before you say you are free. Your booking system, your personal calendar, and anywhere else a date can hide (a shared family calendar, a second shooter's diary if you share one). Only say "I'm free" when all three are clear. Saying it and taking it back is the worst thing you can do to a new enquiry.

Lock in the time, then ask for their details. Once they say yes to a chat, settle the time first. Then ask for email and mobile as a separate short message, with a reason that serves them. DMs get buried. If all you hold is a handle, one busy week and they are gone.

Never make anyone feel chased. Most couples who go quiet are busy, not gone. Follow up a set number of times, then stop warmly. A couple who gets a kind last message might come back in six months. A couple who gets chased will not.

Track every lead by how far it got. Chatting, invited, booked, chat done, plus gone quiet or not a fit when it ends. A CRM, a spreadsheet or a notebook, it does not matter. What matters is that you can see where your conversations stall.

The shape of the conversation

1. **Open.** Congratulations and thanks, one detail mirrored back, one easy question or the invite.
2. **Qualify.** One or two easy questions at most. Date and venue first, then coverage or feel.
3. **Date check.** The moment they give a date, check all three calendars before you reply.
4. **Mirror.** Play back what they want in one line.
5. **Invite.** A quick 15 minute chat. Ask first. No days, no link yet.
6. **Lock it in.** Two free times, then the booking link as a fallback, then email and mobile.
7. **Nudge once inside 24 hours** if they go quiet after the invite. Everything after that lives in the Follow-Up Vault.
8. **Close warmly** when it is booked, not a fit, or over.

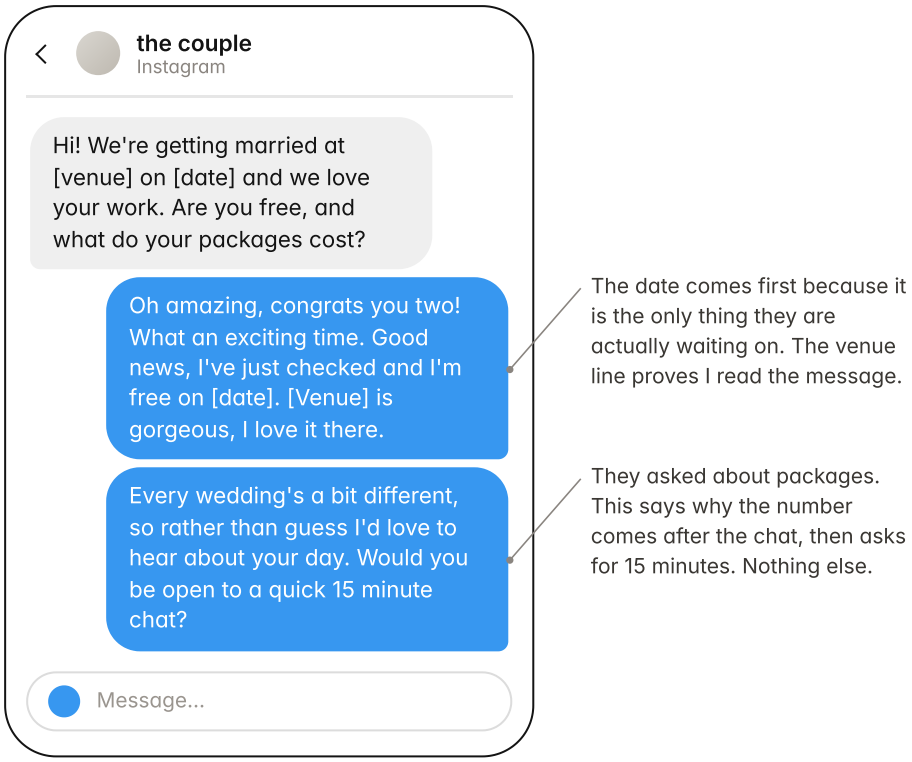
Scripts by situation

Each screen below is one exchange. The grey bubble is an example of what a couple might write. The blue bubbles are mine. Two at most, every time.

CONTENTS

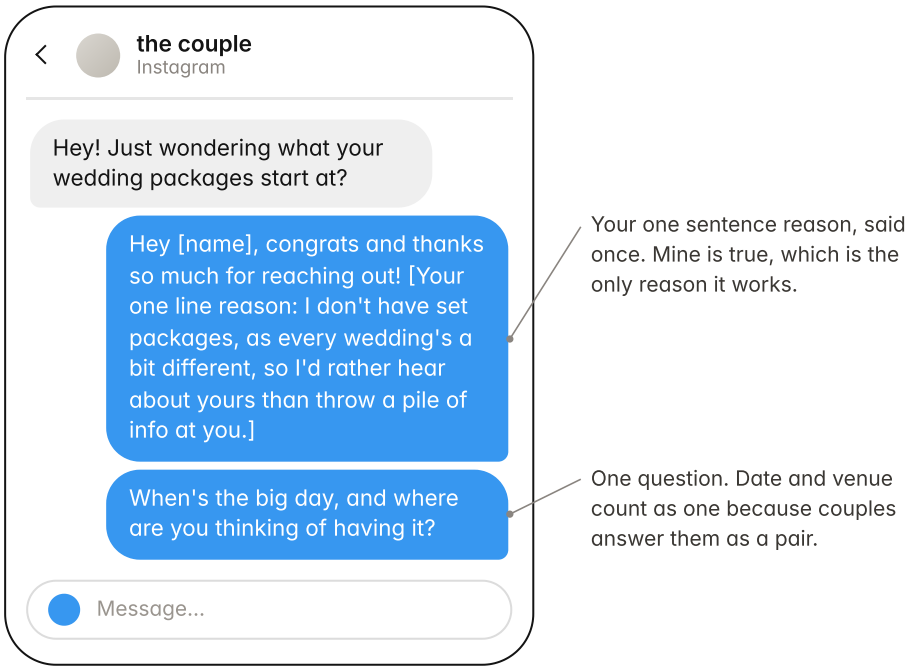
FIRST REPLY WHEN THEY GIVE A DATE AND VENUE (INCLUDING PRICE AND PACKAGE ASKS)

Check the date in all three calendars first.



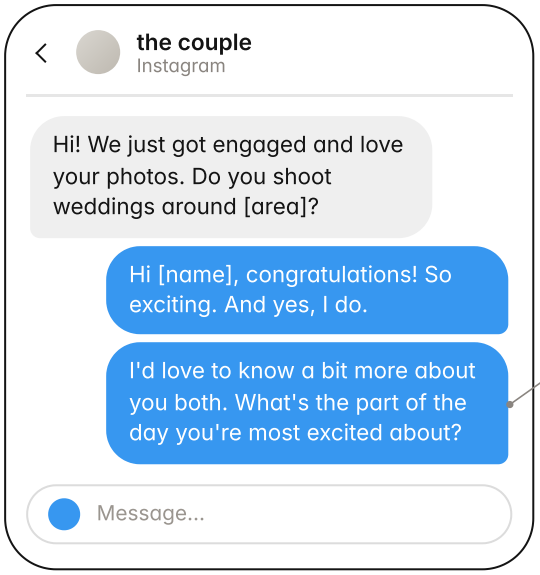
If they asked for prices, this reply still works. You have answered the question that matters more (are you free) and given the reason the number comes after the chat.

FIRST REPLY WHEN THERE IS NO DATE YET AND THEY ASK ABOUT PRICE



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FIRST REPLY WHEN THEY HAVE NOT ASKED ABOUT PRICE



They have not asked about money, so I do not bring it up. A curiosity question gets a longer answer than "what's your date".

A COLD "HOW MUCH FOR A WEDDING?"



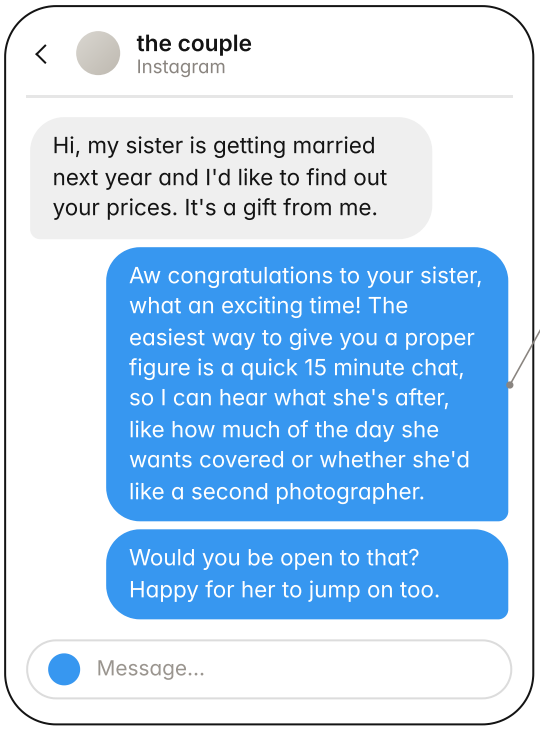
Half of these are a parent, a friend or a bot. One question sorts that out before I spend any effort.

The date check comes before any talk of price. If I am booked, the price was never the question.

CONTENTS

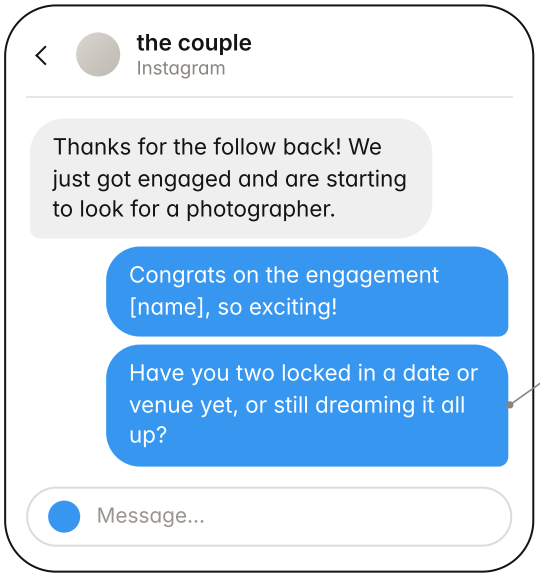
SOMEONE ASKING ON BEHALF OF A SISTER, FRIEND, SON OR DAUGHTER

Match their tone. A parent is often more formal than the couple would be.



A sibling or parent cannot answer the questions I need, so the invite names what I would ask and makes it easy to bring the couple along.

A NEW FOLLOWER WHO IS ENGAGED AND "JUST LOOKING"

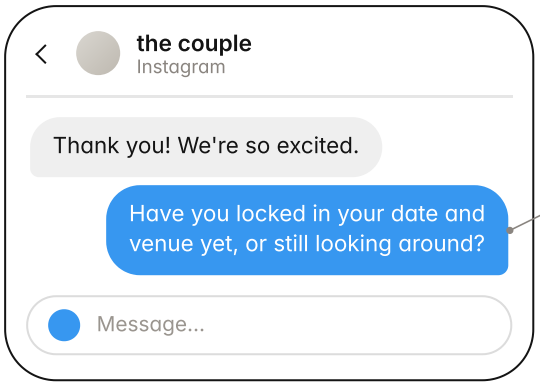


"Or still dreaming it all up" gives them an easy answer if nothing is locked in. Nobody feels behind.

CONTENTS

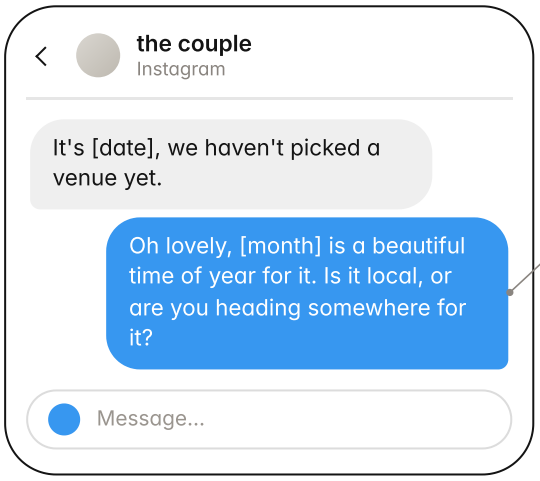
QUALIFYING, ONE QUESTION AT A TIME

When they have only said thanks:



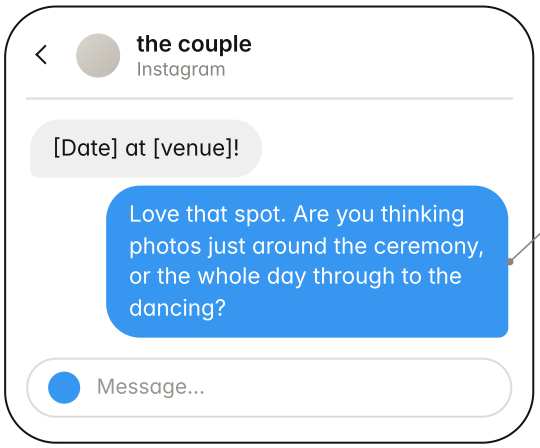
This or that questions get answered. Open questions get ignored.

When they have a date and no venue:



Mirror one detail, then one question. Local or away changes how I would run the day, so it is the question worth asking.

When they have both:

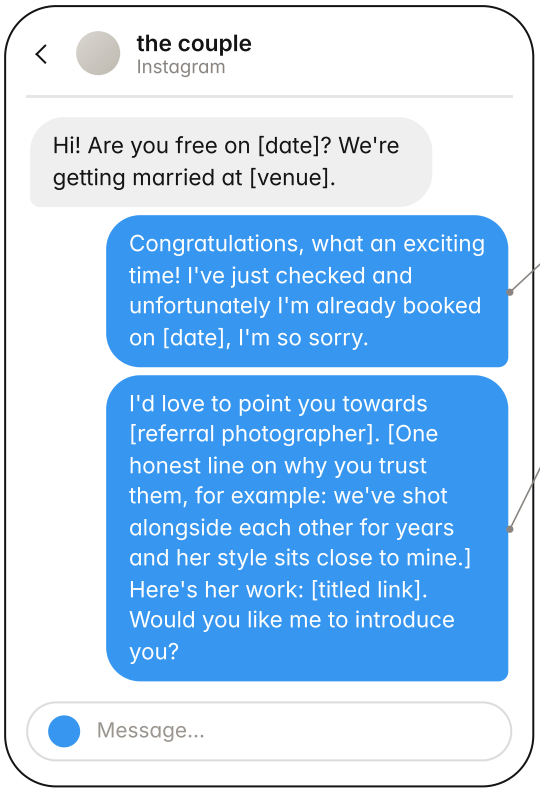


Coverage framed as moments, never hours. They picture their day and I get what I need for the chat.

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WHEN THE DATE IS TAKEN

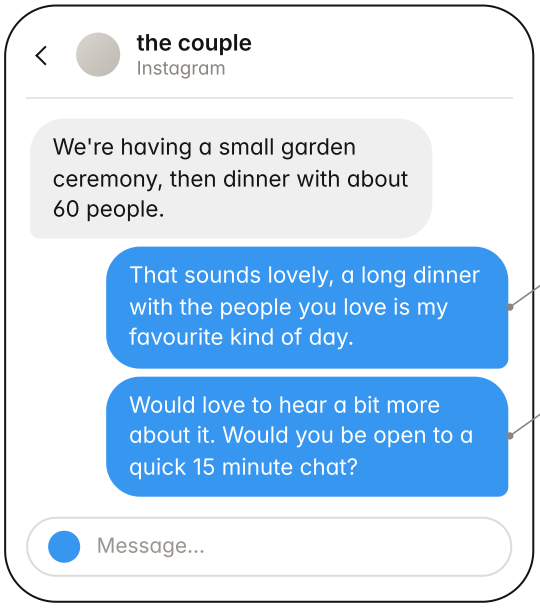
Only after all three calendars show it booked. If the date might move, ask about that first.



If yes, get their email and send a short introduction email that night, copying your colleague in. Only refer people you would book yourself.

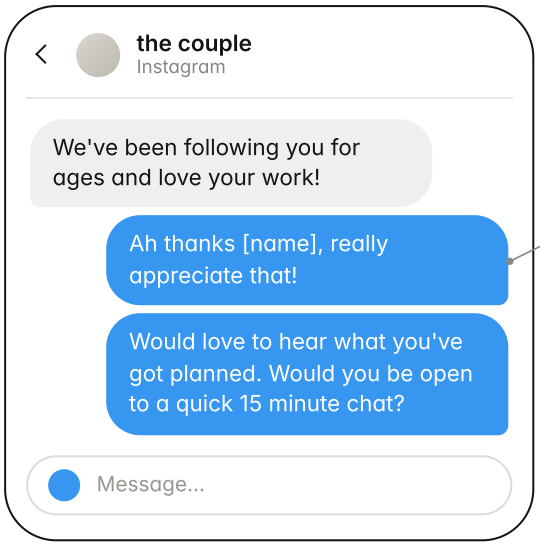
THE INVITE

Ask first. No days, no link.



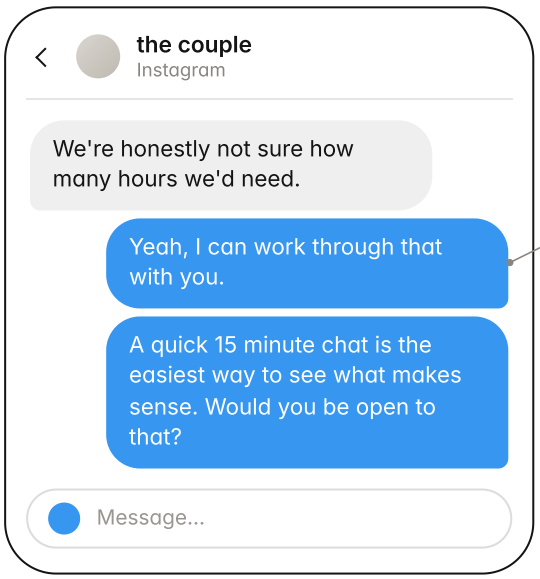
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When they say they love your work:



Thank them and move on. Lingering on the compliment makes the next line feel like a pitch.

When they are unsure how much coverage they need:



Their uncertainty is the reason for the chat. Name it and offer to solve it there, not here.

"WHAT WOULD WE TALK ABOUT?"

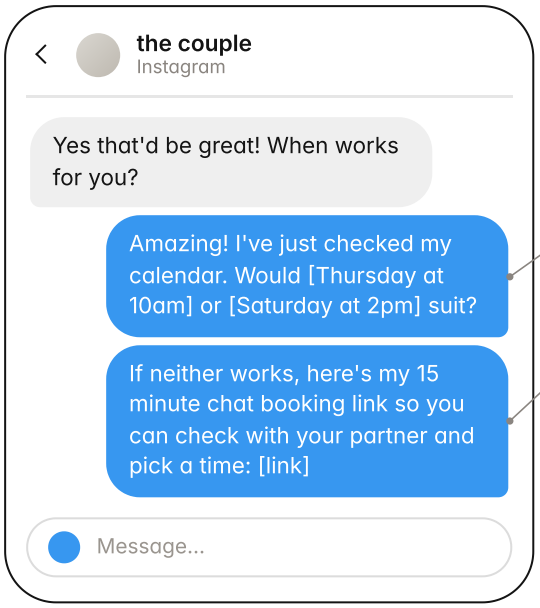


Plain words and three small things. If it sounds like an agenda, they will not book it.

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THEY SAY YES, OR ASK WHEN WORKS

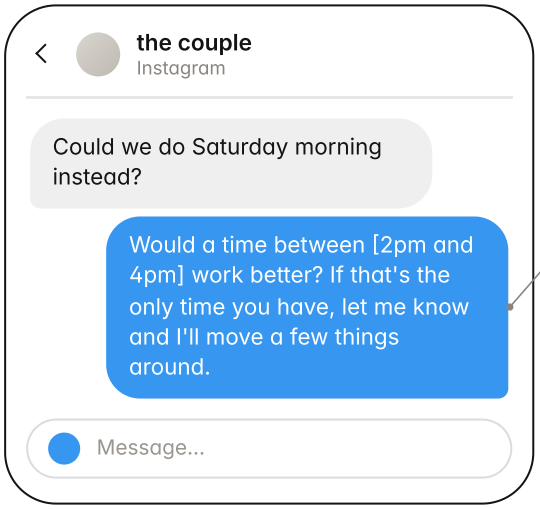
Pick two times that are free in every calendar you keep. Weekdays first. Never offer a time you would resent.



Two specific times beats "when suits you". Both checked in every calendar first.

The link is the fallback, never the first move, and it is titled so it does not read as a bare URL.

If they suggest a time you cannot do:

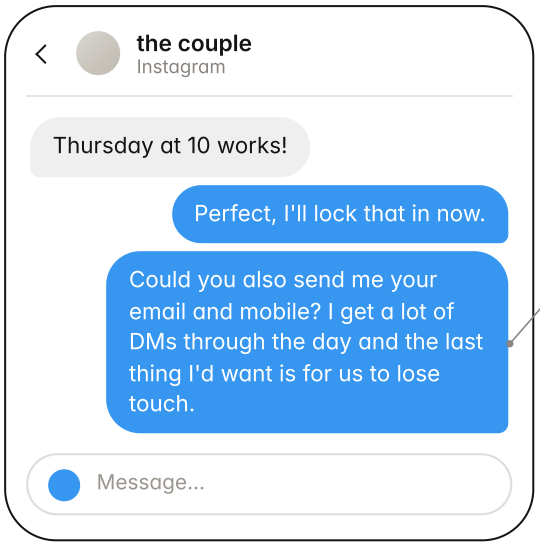


Offer a window, then show flexibility. Never a flat no to the only time they have.

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EMAIL AND MOBILE, STRAIGHT AFTER THE TIME IS SETTLED

Its own short message. One ask per conversation.



The reason serves them, and it is true. Sent as its own message so it does not get buried under the time.

If they only give one:

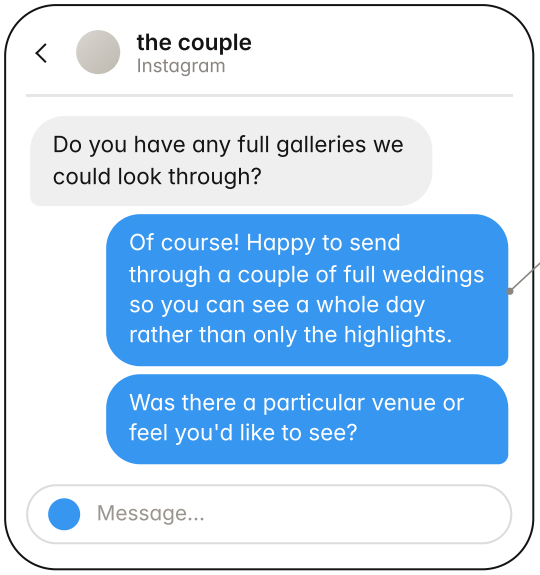


One gentle second ask, with a reason. After this I leave it.

If they skip it twice, leave it. Ask again in the booking confirmation or the last follow-up, never a third time in chat.

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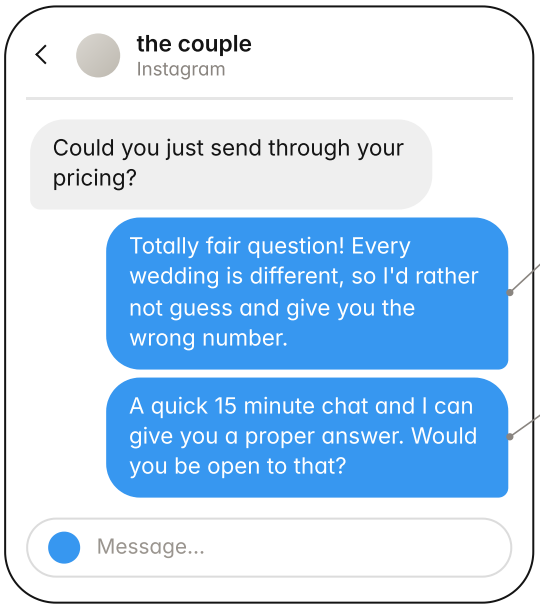
THEY WANT TO SEE MORE WORK



Send one titled gallery at a time, picked to match their venue or feel. Not a list. Invite the chat in your next message.

PRICE PUSHBACK, FIRST PUSH ("CAN YOU JUST SEND PRICING?")

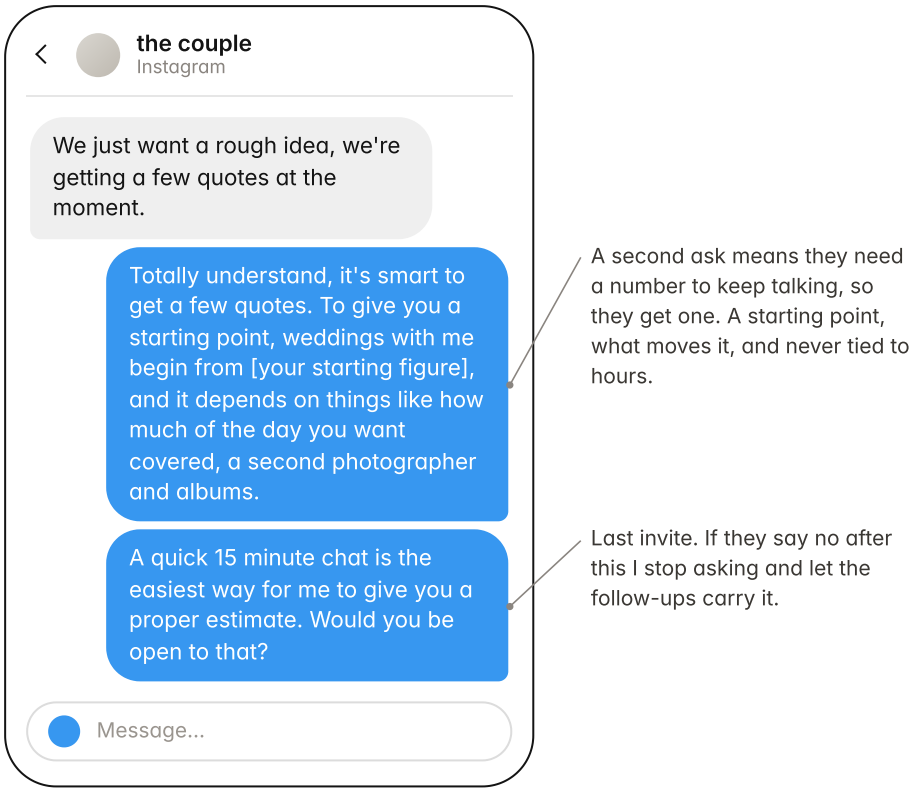
A first push is normal. No figure yet.



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PRICE PUSHBACK, SECOND PUSH ("JUST WANT A ROUGH IDEA, WE'RE GETTING QUOTES")

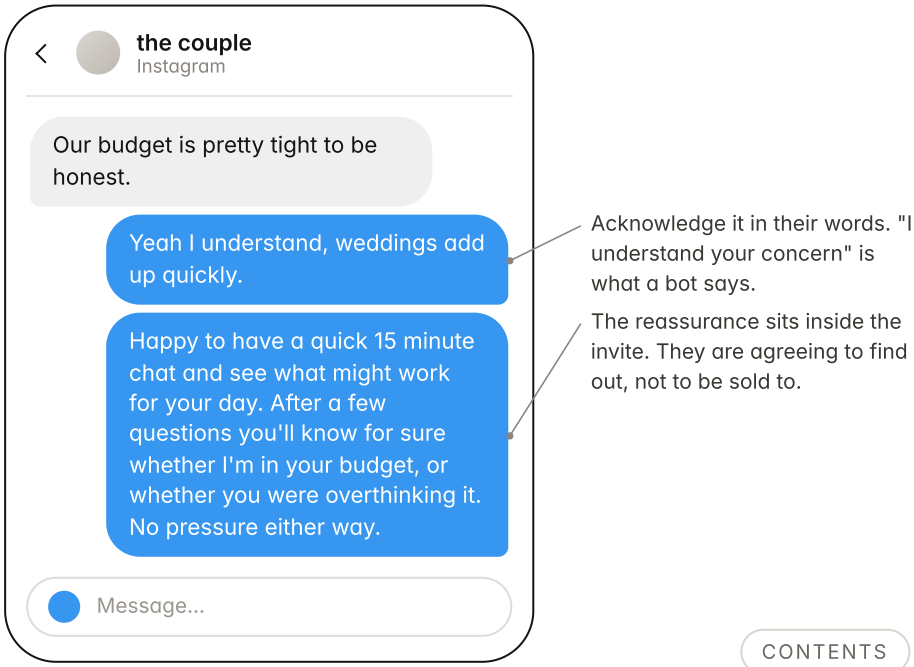
Any second ask about cost counts, however they word it. Now give a starting point, once, and never tie it to an hour count.



If they clearly do not want a chat after this, stop inviting. Leave the door open and let the follow-ups do the rest.

"OUR BUDGET IS TIGHT"

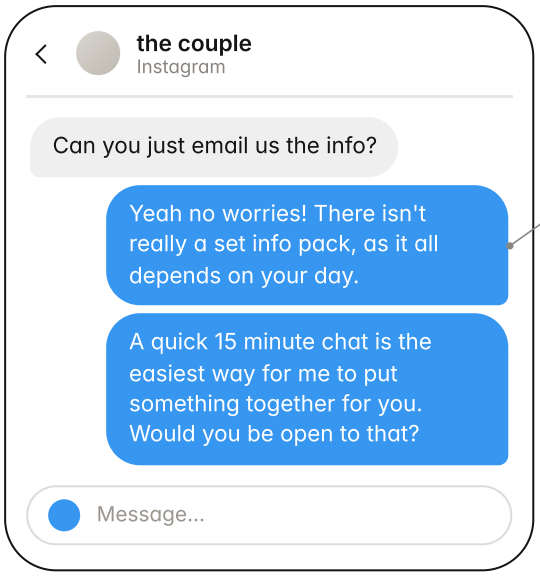
Do not skip past it. Put the reassurance inside the invite.



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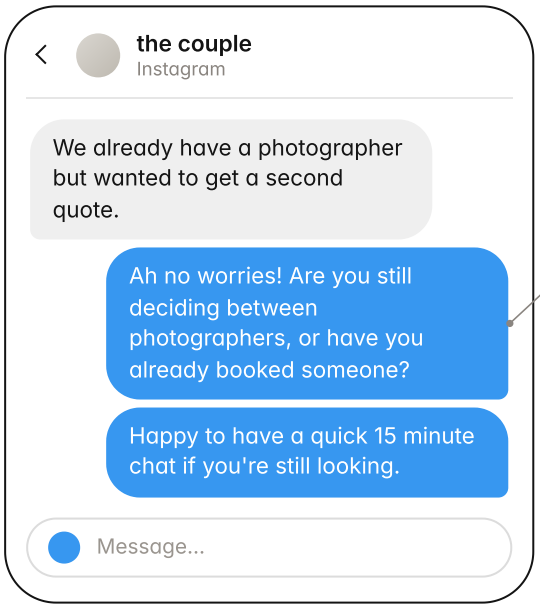
"CAN YOU JUST EMAIL THE INFO?"

Never promise a guide or prices by email.



Honest and true for me. If you have a set pack, you need a different line here, and maybe a different policy.

"WE ALREADY HAVE A PHOTOGRAPHER, WE JUST WANT A SECOND QUOTE"



One question tells me whether this is a real enquiry or a price check against someone else's quote.

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"WE'LL THINK ABOUT IT" OR "NOT READY YET"

Do not re-offer times straight away.



Hand them the control. A couple who chose to be checked in on does not feel chased when it happens.

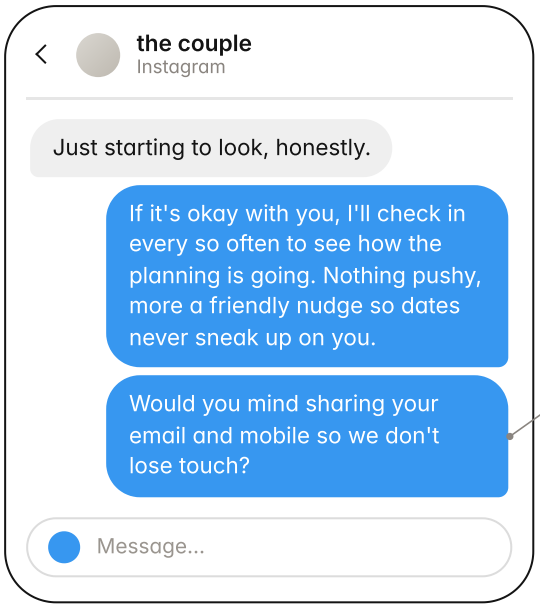
EARLY COUPLE, DATE TWO OR MORE YEARS AWAY



Early couples are not ready to book anything. This finds out whether they are shopping or browsing, which decides the follow-up.

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Then, on their next reply, ask permission to stay in touch and get their details.



Permission first, then the details. In that order it never feels like a data grab.

VIDEO

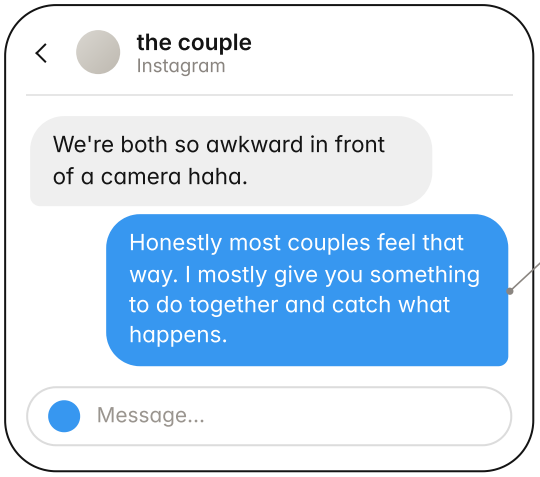
If you are photography only, say so warmly and offer an introduction. Never quote a film studio's prices or promise their availability.



Offer the introduction, never the price. Never promise another studio's availability.

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POSING NERVES



Name how common it is, then say what I actually do. The specific beats "don't worry".

NOT A LEAD

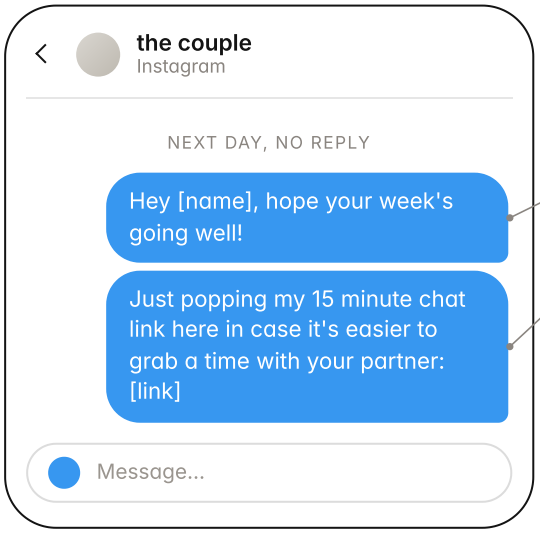


A compliment is not an enquiry. One friendly question finds out, with no awkwardness either way.

If not: no worries at all, when the time comes feel free to reach out.

THE NUDGE INSIDE 24 HOURS

If they went quiet after the invite, send one nudge inside 24 hours. Instagram closes its messaging window after that and any automation stops, so this one is sent by hand.



Light and human. No "just checking in", and no mention of them not replying.

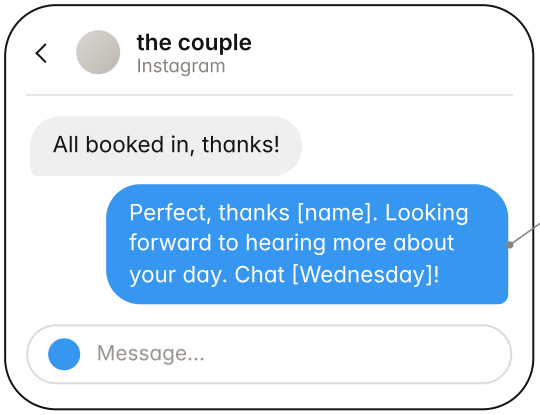
Now the link makes sense, because they already said they were interested. Sent inside 24 hours or Instagram will not let you.

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Every follow-up after this one is in the Follow-Up Vault, by day and channel. Any reply from the couple resets the clock.

CLOSING WARMLY

When it is booked:



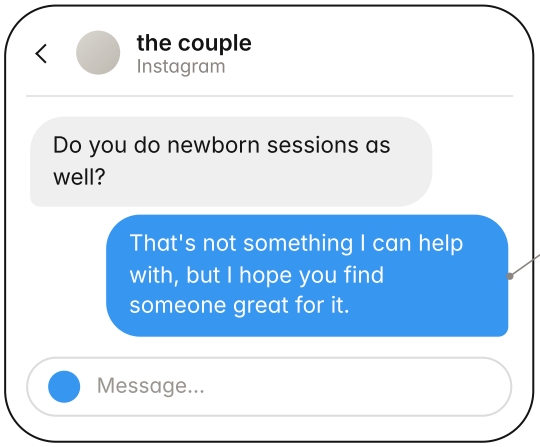
Confirm the day. Warm, short, done.

When they have gone with someone else:



Mean it. This couple has friends who are engaged.

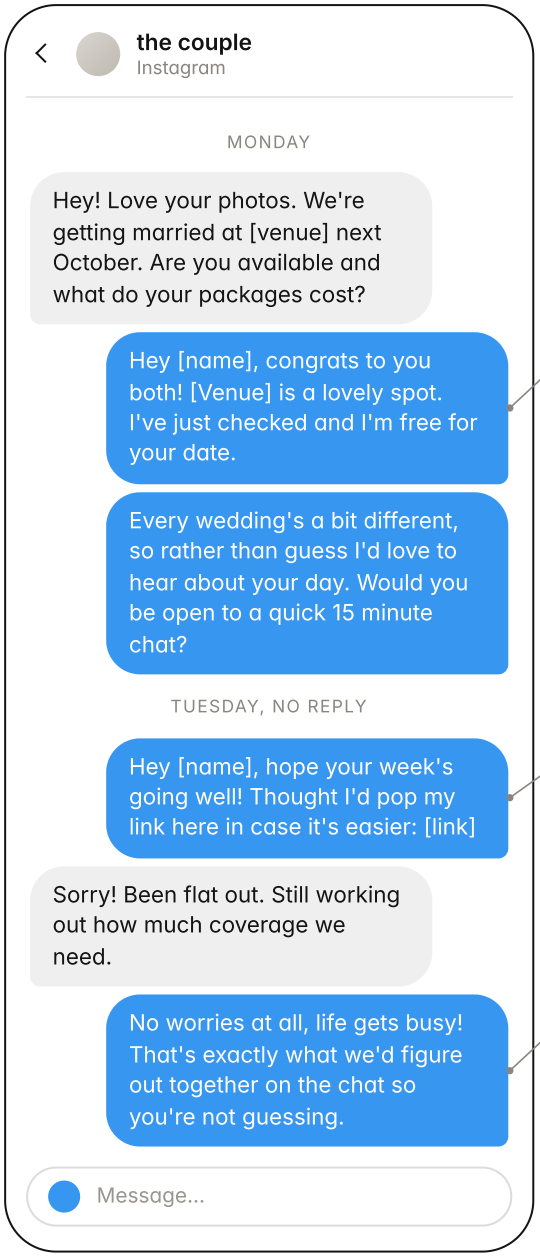
When it is not a fit:



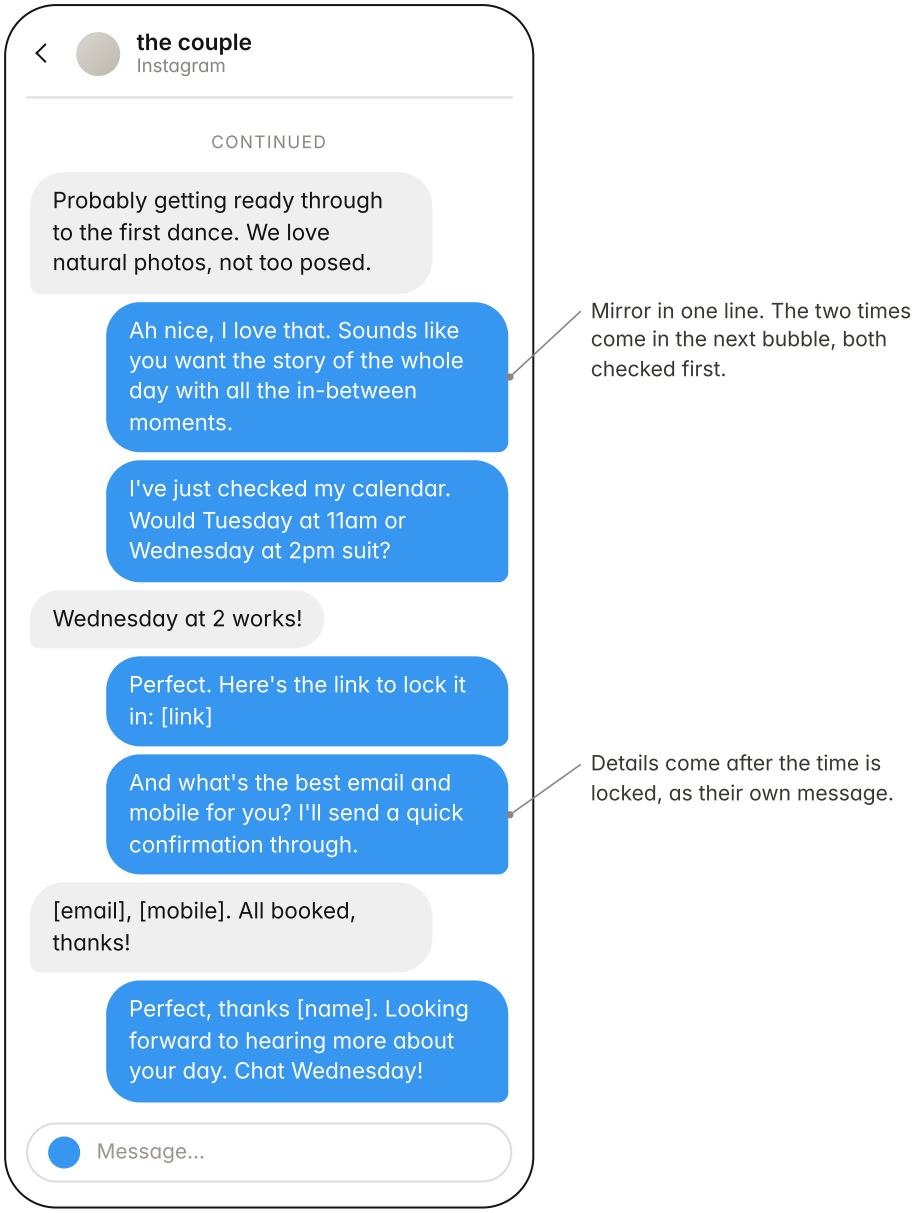
A clean no that still helps them.

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One conversation, start to finish



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Three things were checked before any of that went out: the date in every calendar, the two times offered, and the booking itself.

Words I have swapped

INSTEAD OF	I SAY
Would you like to book a phone call?	Would you be open to a quick 15 minute chat?
Please see my packages attached	I don't have set packages, as every wedding's a bit different
Your date is available	Good news, I've just checked and I'm free on [date]
I understand your concern about budget	Yeah, weddings add up pretty quickly

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INSTEAD OF	I SAY
Please provide your contact details	What's the best mobile and email for you?
Just following up on my previous message	Hey [name], hope your week's going well!
Please let me know if you have any questions	No stress at all
This is my final follow-up	One last note from me, and then I'll leave you to it

And the things that give you away as a bot every time: every message starting with "Hey [name], congrats!", perfect grammar with no contractions, neat lists of three, more than one emoji, long dashes in the middle of sentences, "Absolutely!", "Great question!", "Feel free to reach out".

Tracking

Every DM lead gets a line somewhere you can see it: the date they messaged, the stage they reached, and the date the next touch is due.

Chatting, then invited, then booked, then chat done. Gone quiet or not a fit when it ends.

Once a week, look at where the stalls are. If most leads stall at "invited", your invite needs work. If they stall at "chatting", you are asking too many questions before you invite.

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PART 2 OF 5

Enquiry-to-Booking sequence

The emails and texts from the moment an enquiry lands to the moment a call is booked, plus the three habits that stop couples ghosting you.

The first reply has one job. Book the call. Not explain your packages, not send a guide, not quote a price. Every line in it either answers the question they asked or moves them one step closer to a 15 minute conversation. Once I understood that, my first reply got shorter and my bookings went up.

The five rules

1. **Answer the date first.** Couples want to know if you are free. Say it in the first two lines.
2. **No price list in the first reply.** Ask a question or two instead. You cannot quote well when you are guessing what they need. If they asked for a price directly, give a starting point and then invite the call. Never dodge.
3. **One next step per email.** One link, one ask. Never two.
4. **Close the loop.** Every enquiry ends as booked, not right for us, or released. Nothing sits in limbo.
5. **You press send on the personal ones.** Automate the acknowledgement and the reminders. Write the first reply and the proposal yourself, with these as the base.

The three-calendar date check

Before you tell any couple you are free, check three places:

1. Your booking system or CRM, where contracts and retainers live.
2. Your personal calendar, where family, holidays and the things you will not move live.
3. The third place dates hide for you. A shared family calendar, a second shooter's roster, a venue coordinator role, a day job shift pattern.

Only when all three are clear do you write "Good news first, I'm free on [date]." If one is blocked, the date is taken. If one is unclear, say you are checking and come back the same day. Taking back a "yes" is worse than a slow "let me check".

Write the three places down and tape them above your desk. Then it is a habit, not a memory test.

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The two day follow-up to-do

The moment you send a first reply, set a to-do for two days later: "Follow up [names] if no reply." In your CRM as an automated task, in your phone as a reminder, on paper if that is what you use. The to-do is set before you move to the next email. Not later, not when you remember.

Most ghosting is the photographer's. The couple replied in their head, got busy, and nobody nudged them. The to-do is the fix. What you say on day two, five and twelve is in the Follow-Up Vault. This pack makes sure the day arrives.

The shape

STAGE	WHAT GOES OUT	WHEN	SENT BY
Enquiry lands	Instant text, no link, no price	Straight away, any hour	Automation
First reply	Email, date free, date taken, or asked for price	Same day if you can, next business day at worst	You
Two day to-do set	Nothing sent yet	The moment you reply	You
Call booked	One confirmation email, reminder the day before	Instantly, then the day before	Automation
After the call	The proposal email (Part 3)	Same day, while it is fresh	You
Booked	Welcome email	When contract and retainer are both in	Automation, checked by you

Any reply from the couple stops every automation. From then on it is a conversation, not a sequence.

Placeholders

PLACEHOLDER	WHAT GOES IN
[Partner 1] [Partner 2]	First names. Use both in the greeting
[Wedding date]	Weekday plus full date, for example "Saturday 14 March 2028"
[Venue]	The ceremony or reception venue they named
[Call link]	Your booking link for the 15 minute chat
[Planning resource]	One free, useful thing you give couples: a timeline planner, a light guide, a family photo list

CONTENTS

PLACEHOLDER	WHAT GOES IN
[Referral photographer]	A colleague you trust for dates you cannot take
[Retainer terms]	Your booking terms, for example "a signed contract and a 50% retainer"
[Starting figure]	Your lowest starting price, used only when they ask directly

Keep paragraphs to one to three sentences. Most of these emails sit between 80 and 200 words. No emoji in email. One exclamation mark is plenty. Sign off with your normal signature and do not type your name twice.

Lines marked PERSONAL are where you write one real sentence about this couple. Never leave a generic line there. If you have nothing real, cut the line.

The instant text (automation)

> Hi [Partner 1], it's [your first name] from [business name]. Thanks so much for your enquiry, and congratulations! I'll reply properly by email shortly.

No link. No price. It tells them a real person saw it.

First reply: your date is free (you send)

Subject options:

- Congratulations [Partner 1] and [Partner 2]! Your [Venue] wedding
- Your [Month Year] wedding date

CONTENTS

- [Partner 1] and [Partner 2], good news on your date

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Congratulations to you both, and thank you so much for reaching out.
>
> Good news first. I'm free on [Wedding date], so your date is open with me.
>
> PERSONAL: [One line that shows you read their enquiry. Their venue, how they met, something they said they care about.]
>
> I'd love to give you all the information on how I work and what's included. Before I do, I'd like to find out a little more about what you have planned, so I'm not guessing or suggesting things you don't need.
>
> Can I ask: [one easy question, for example "What's the part of the day you're most looking forward to?"]
>
> If it's easier to talk it through, you can grab a time for a quick 15 minute chat here: [Call link]
>
> No rush at all.

Two questions is the most. One is better.

First reply: your date is taken (you send)

Subject: About your [Wedding date] wedding

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Congratulations, and thank you so much for thinking of me.
>
> I wanted to let you know straight away. Unfortunately I'm already committed on [Wedding date], which is a real shame, because [one honest line about why their plans suit how you shoot].
>
> If your date has any flexibility, these dates are still open:
>
> - [Open date 1]
> - [Open date 2]
> - [Open date 3]
>
> If [Wedding date] is locked in, I'd recommend [Referral photographer]. [One line on why you trust them.] If her work feels right, reply with your best email and I'll introduce you both.
>
> Wishing you both all the best with the planning.

Only list open dates if they are real and close to theirs. Only refer people you would book yourself. If you do introduce them, send the introduction that night and copy your colleague in.

CONTENTS

First reply: they asked for prices straight away (you send)

Subject: Your [Month Year] wedding, and a straight answer on pricing

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Congratulations, and thank you for getting in touch.
>
> Good news first. I'm free on [Wedding date].
>
> You asked about pricing, so here's a straight answer. My weddings start from [Starting figure]. Where you land depends on the shape of your day, and that's the bit I don't want to guess.
>
> The quickest way to get you a real number is a 15 minute chat. I'll ask a few questions about your day and then send a proposal built around what you actually need, nothing more and nothing less.
>
> You can grab a time here: [Call link]

One starting figure only. Never a full price list in an email. If you would rather not quote a figure at all, use the first version and say pricing follows the chat.

When another couple wants the same date

This is the paragraph I use when two couples are looking at one date. It goes in the first reply if it is already true, and in the proposal email after the call (Part 3) if it becomes true. Three rules: only when it is true, say it on the call before you write it, and never name the other couple.

> I also want to be upfront about your date. It isn't held until a signed contract and retainer are in, and I have a chat [on Thursday] with another couple looking at [Wedding date]. Whoever books first will secure it. I'd hate for you to miss out, so if you're leaning towards going ahead, let me know and I'll make it easy.

It is a fact, said once, calmly. It is not a pressure line, and it stops being true the day the other couple decides. Update it or remove it the same day.

Call booked: confirmation (automation)

Most booking tools send a reminder on their own, so one confirmation is enough. If yours does not, send the same email again the day before with the subject "Speak tomorrow".

CONTENTS

Subject: You're booked in, [Partner 1] and [Partner 2]

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Lovely, you're locked in for [Call date and time] ([time zone]).
>
> Here's the link to join: [Meeting link]
>
> It's a relaxed chat. I'll ask about your day, what you're picturing and anything you're unsure about. Bring any questions you have. If you can both be on the call, even better.
>
> One thing to think about beforehand, if you have a minute: [one easy prompt, for example "the moment of the day you most want to remember"].
>
> If something comes up and you need to move it, you can change the time here: [Reschedule link]
>
> Speak soon.

Booked: welcome (automation, checked by you)

Trigger only when the contract is signed and the retainer has landed. A verbal yes is not booked. A signed contract on its own is not booked.

Subject: You're booked! Welcome, [Partner 1] and [Partner 2]

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> It's official. Your contract and retainer are in, and [Wedding date] is locked in with me. I'm so excited to be part of it.
>
> Here's what happens from here:
>
> - [Step 1, for example "You'll get your receipt and a copy of your signed contract by email."]
> - [Step 2, for example "Around three months before the wedding, we'll plan the timeline together."]
> - [Step 3, for example "The week of the wedding, I'll send a final check-in."]
>
> You don't need to do anything else right now. Enjoy being booked in.
>
> If anything changes, or a question pops into your head at 11pm, just reply here.
>
> Can't wait to celebrate with you both.

Sell certainty here: tell them when they will hear from you next. If you include a pre-wedding session, add one line on how to book it.

Pipeline stages to set up

1. New enquiry

CONTENTS

2. Replied (first reply sent, two day to-do set)
3. Call booked
4. Proposal sent
5. Booked (won)
6. Not proceeding (lost, with a reason)
7. Nurture (permission given to keep in touch)

Lost reasons worth tracking: date taken, budget, chose someone else, no response, wedding postponed, not the right fit. After three months of tracking these you will know exactly which part of your process to fix next.

Words that work, and words to drop

Use: good news first, quick chat, no rush at all, so I'm not guessing, nothing more and nothing less, close the loop, release the date, completely fine, a quick line either way.

Drop: just checking in, touching base, per my last email, kindly, don't hesitate to contact, I hope this email finds you well, limited spots, act now, your special day, are you still interested?

CONTENTS

PART 3 OF 5

The proposal

A proposal is a note from you, not a quote.

The couple just spent 15 minutes telling you about their day. The proposal proves you listened. It is written in the first person, it recaps what they said in their words, it lists what they get as dot points, and it gives exact dates for when they will see their photos. The price sits inside that, once, plainly. If a couple can read your proposal and not tell it was written for them, it is a quote, and quotes get compared.

I send the proposal the same day as the call, while it is fresh for both of us. Never before a call.

The rules

- **First person singular.** "I'll be with you from the getting ready." Never "our team will provide coverage."
- **Their words, not yours.** If they said "chill", write chill. Do not translate it into "relaxed and organic".
- **Deliverables as dot points.** Short, concrete, in the order of the day. No paragraphs of inclusions.
- **Exact gallery dates.** Not "six to eight weeks". A calendar date you can beat. Work it out from your real turnaround plus a buffer, then write the date down. A date is a promise a couple can hold. A range is a hedge they can feel.
- **One link.** The proposal page or document, if you use one. The email carries the recap, the page carries the detail.
- **Say what booked means.** Signed contract plus retainer received. Not a verbal yes. Say it once, calmly.
- **Read it on your phone before you send it.** No square brackets left anywhere. If you are unsure of a detail, write it more generally and ask the question in the email.

The proposal email

This is the proposal for most couples. If you use a proposal page or a document in your CRM, the email still carries everything below and the page holds the longer version.

Subject options:

- Thank you! Next steps for [Partner 1] and [Partner 2]

CONTENTS

- Your wedding proposal and next steps

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Thank you for taking the time to chat with me [this afternoon]. It was lovely getting to know you both.
>
> PERSONAL: [Name something specific from the call in their words. A tradition, a person, a worry they had. Then their venue, so it reads as written for them. For example: "I loved hearing how much the ceremony with your grandparents there means to you, and I'm already picturing the light at [Venue] around five."]
>
> **What I'd suggest for your day**
>
> - [The shape of the coverage in plain words, as a moment, for example "With you from the getting ready through to the first dance"]
> - [Who is there, for example "Me as your photographer for the whole day" or "Me plus a second photographer for the ceremony and the start of the reception"]
> - [Anything you changed for them on the call]
> - [Anything you promised on the call]
> - [What they receive, for example "Your full gallery, edited, in an online gallery you can download from and share"]
> - [Any product included, for example "A pre-wedding session so you're used to me and the camera before the day"]
>
> **When you'll see your photos**
>
> - A first look of [number] photos by [exact date, for example Tuesday 17 March 2028]
> - Your full gallery by [exact date, for example Friday 8 May 2028]
>
> **The investment**
>
> [Price, once, inc GST if that applies to you.] To lock in [Wedding date], it's [Retainer terms]. Your date is confirmed once the signed contract and retainer are both in. If spreading the balance into instalments suits you better, just say so and I'll set that up.
>
> [If a proposal page or document exists:] Here it is in full, with the contract and payment steps: **[Wedding proposal]** (hyperlinked)
>
> **Next steps**
>
> 1. Have a read through together.
> 2. Reply with any questions, or anything you'd like changed. I'd rather you only pay for what you need.
> 3. When you're ready, sign and pay the retainer and the date is yours.
>
> If it's okay with you, I'll check in on [specific day] to see how you're both feeling.

Then your normal signature.

CONTENTS

THE COMPETING ENQUIRY PARAGRAPH

Only when it is true, only after you have said it on the call, never naming the other couple. It sits directly under the investment paragraph.

> I also want to be upfront about your date. It isn't held until a signed contract and retainer are in, and I have a chat [on Thursday] with another couple looking at [Wedding date]. Whoever books first will secure it. I'd hate for you to miss out, so if you're leaning towards going ahead, let me know and I'll make it easy.

CONTENTS

Worked example

Here is the same email filled in for an imagined couple, so you can see the length and the feel. Every detail is invented.

> Hi Priya and Tom,
>
> Thank you for taking the time to chat with me this afternoon. It was lovely getting to know you both.
>
> I loved hearing that the bit you're most nervous about is the family photos, and the bit you'll treasure most is the ceremony with Tom's grandmother there. The garden at your venue faces west, so your portraits will land in the softest light of the day.
>
> **What I'd suggest for your day**
>
> - With you from the getting ready at the house through to the first dance
> - Me as your photographer for the whole day
> - A family photo list we build together three weeks out, so the family photos take 20 minutes, not an hour
> - A sunset portrait window of 25 minutes, planned into your timeline
> - Your full gallery, edited, in an online gallery you can download from and share
> - A relaxed pre-wedding session so you're used to me and the camera before the day
>
> **When you'll see your photos**
>
> - A first look of 30 photos by Tuesday 17 March 2028
> - Your full gallery by Friday 8 May 2028
>
> **The investment**
>
> [Price] inc GST. To lock in Saturday 14 March 2028, it's a signed contract and a 50% retainer. Your date is confirmed once both are in. If spreading the balance into instalments suits you better, just say so and I'll set that up.
>
> **Next steps**
>
> 1. Have a read through together.
> 2. Reply with any questions, or anything you'd like changed. I'd rather you only pay for what you need.
> 3. When you're ready, sign and pay the retainer and the date is yours.
>
> If it's okay with you, I'll check in on Thursday to see how you're both feeling.

Around 250 words. It took five minutes to write off the notes from the call, and almost all of that time went on the second paragraph.

CONTENTS

If you use a proposal page

Some CRMs let you send a designed page with the contract and payment attached. If yours does, build it once and change only the personal blocks per couple. The order follows the couple's thinking: do I like you, do I trust how you work, what does it cost, what is the catch, what do I do now.

BLOCK	JOB	CHANGES PER COUPLE
1. Hero	Their names, their date, their venue, one photo	Yes
2. Letter and recap	The proposal email above, as the opening	Yes
3. How I work	Three beliefs, each answering a worry you hear on calls	No
4. From here to your gallery	Six steps from booking to gallery, with your exact gallery dates in the last one	Dates only
5. Your options	Two to four collections as cards, same inclusions in the same order, price once per card	Only if you tailored one
6. Add to your day	Three to five add-ons, each with one line on when it is worth it	No
7. Questions couples ask	Six to eight real questions from your inbox, answered in two or three sentences	No
8. Ready to book	Choose, sign, pay. The booked rule once. One button	No
9. Your details	Only the fields you will use. Prefill what you already have	No

Notes on the blocks that cause trouble:

- **Hero.** Their names first, your logo small. No "proposal prepared for". Their names already say it.
- **How I work.** If you cannot picture a couple saying "yes, that's what I want", it is a slogan, not a belief. Cut it. Mine are about planning the day around the light, directing gently then letting moments happen, and finishing the plan weeks before the day. Yours will be different.
- **Your options.** Describe coverage by the moments it covers, not by hours. Couples picture their day in moments. Hours make them start counting. Name the collections after what they give, never bronze, silver and gold. If you tailored one on the call, mark it "Suggested for you" and put it first. No crossed-out prices, no "limited time".
- **Add-ons.** "Worth it if you have over 120 guests or two getting-ready locations" helps a couple decide. "Second photographer" on its own does not.
- **Questions.** Keep a list of what couples ask on calls for a month and you will have it. Every answer must match your contract. If they disagree, the couple trusts the contract and stops trusting you.
- **Test it as a couple.** Fake names, choose a collection, sign, reach the payment screen. Then do it again on your phone. Check the greeting with one name filled in and with two. "Dear and ," is the first thing a couple sees if your merge fields fail.

CONTENTS

Whatever tool you use, three things link in order: the proposal, the contract, the first payment. If the couple has to leave the page to find any of them, you will lose some of them in the gap.

CONTENTS

PART 4 OF 5

Objection replies

The five things couples say when they are close to booking and not quite there, and what I say back. Each one has an email version and a DM version. The email is longer because email can hold a thought. The DM is two bubbles because that is what a DM can hold.

Before the scripts, the stance that sits under all of them.

Where I stand on discounting

I do not discount. Not for a Sunday, not for a short day, not for a couple I really like, not to beat another quote. Here is why, and it has nothing to do with pride.

A discount teaches the couple that the first price was never real. Every price you quote after that is a starting point for a negotiation. The couples who booked you at full price hear about it, because couples talk. And the couple who got the discount now wonders what else was padded.

A gifted product does the same job in disguise. Throwing in the album to close the booking tells them the album was worth nothing to you. If you sell albums, you have just made every future album harder to sell.

So the rule is simple. Never cut the price. Never give away a product to close. If something has to move, move the scope or offer a credit.

- **Move the scope.** Fewer hours of coverage, no second photographer, the pre-wedding session taken out. The price falls because they are buying less, and every line still costs what it costs.
- **Offer a credit.** If you want to do something generous, make it a credit toward something they would buy later: prints, an album upgrade, an anniversary session. It costs you less than a discount, it lands after the wedding when they love you most, and it never touches the price of the wedding itself.

Spreading payments is not a discount. If the total is right and the timing is the problem, change the timing. Instalments across the months before the wedding are fine. A tiny first payment is not, because it invites an easy yes and an easy cancel. Keep the retainer meaningful and spread the balance.

One more thing. Say your price once, plainly, and then stop talking about it. The urge to justify a number is what makes it sound negotiable.

CONTENTS

1. Price pushback

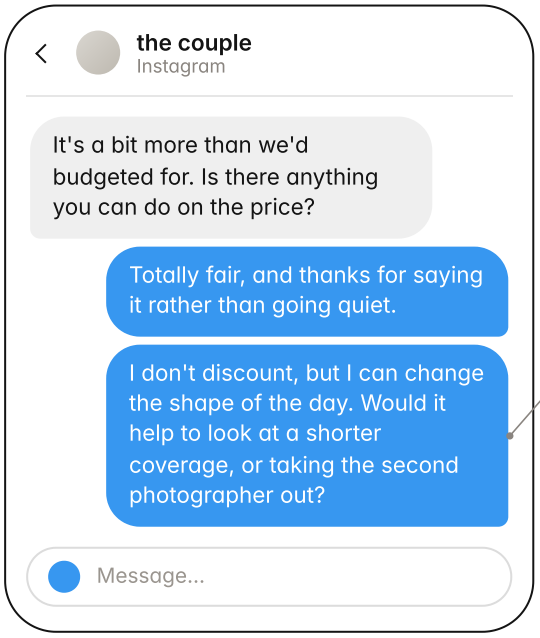
"That's more than we expected." "It's a bit out of our range." "Can you do anything on the price?"

Hold the price, acknowledge the reaction, and offer to change the shape of the day instead.

Email

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Thank you for being straight with me. It's a lot of money, and I'd rather you said so than went quiet.
>
> I don't discount, and I'll tell you why. Every couple I work with pays the same for the same thing, and that's the only way I can look any of them in the eye. What I can do is change the shape of what you're buying.
>
> A few ways that could look:
>
> - [Fewer hours, for example "Start at the ceremony instead of the getting ready, which brings the coverage down to [X] hours"]
> - [Remove an inclusion, for example "Take out the second photographer. With [guest count] guests and one location I can cover it well on my own"]
> - [Move something later, for example "Leave the album out for now and decide after you've seen the gallery"]
>
> If one of those feels right, tell me and I'll send a revised proposal tonight. And if the numbers just don't work, that's completely fine too. I'd rather you had the right photographer than a stretched budget.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

DM



The position in one line, then the shape of the day as the thing that moves. Never the price.

CONTENTS

2. The budget question

"What's your budget?" is a question I never ask on a call. I listen for it instead. But when a couple raises budget themselves, before or after the proposal, I treat it as the best thing they could have said.

"We're working to a budget of around [figure]." "Is there anything you can do for [figure]?" "We only have [figure] for photography."

Email, before the proposal

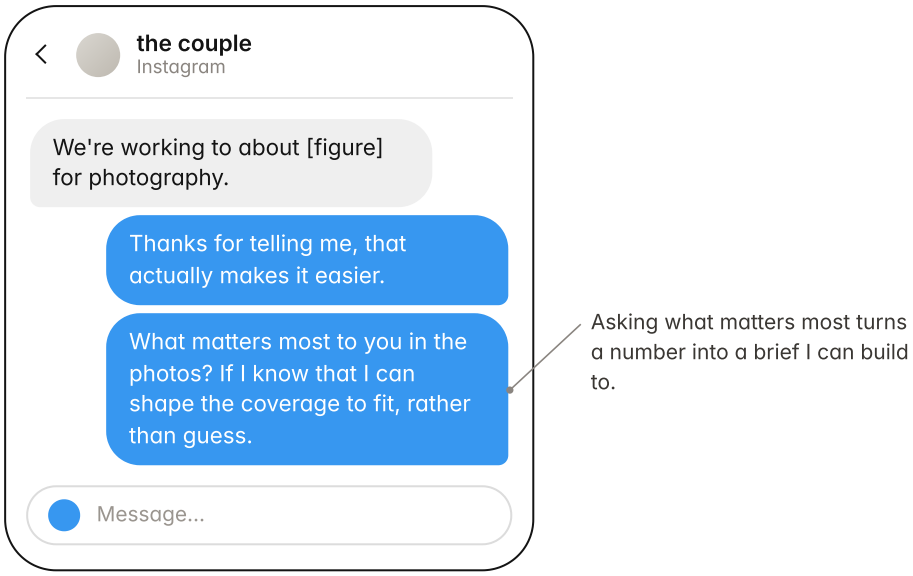
> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Thank you for telling me. Budget is the conversation a lot of my favourite couples have with me before they book, so I'm glad you raised it.
>
> Can I ask one thing before I put anything together? What matters most to you in the photos? The whole day told start to finish, the portraits, the family, the party. If I know that, I can shape coverage that fits [figure] and spends it on the right parts of the day, rather than guessing.
>
> Every wedding I shoot is built this way. The gap between what you have and what you need is often smaller than it looks on paper.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

Email, after the proposal

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Thanks for letting me know where you've landed. [Figure] is a real number and I can work with it.
>
> The proposal I sent covers [the shape of the day]. To bring it to [figure], here's what I'd change:
>
> - [The change, for example "Finish after the first dance rather than staying through to the end of the night"]
> - [The change, for example "Leave the pre-wedding session out"]
>
> That keeps [what matters most to them, in their words] exactly as we talked about. The parts I'd take out are the parts you said mattered least.
>
> If that works, I'll send the revised proposal through tonight.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

CONTENTS

DM



What I never do here: drop the price to meet the figure and keep the same scope. That is a discount wearing a budget costume, and the couple knows it.

3. Still deciding

"We're still deciding." "We're talking to a couple of other photographers." "We need a bit more time."

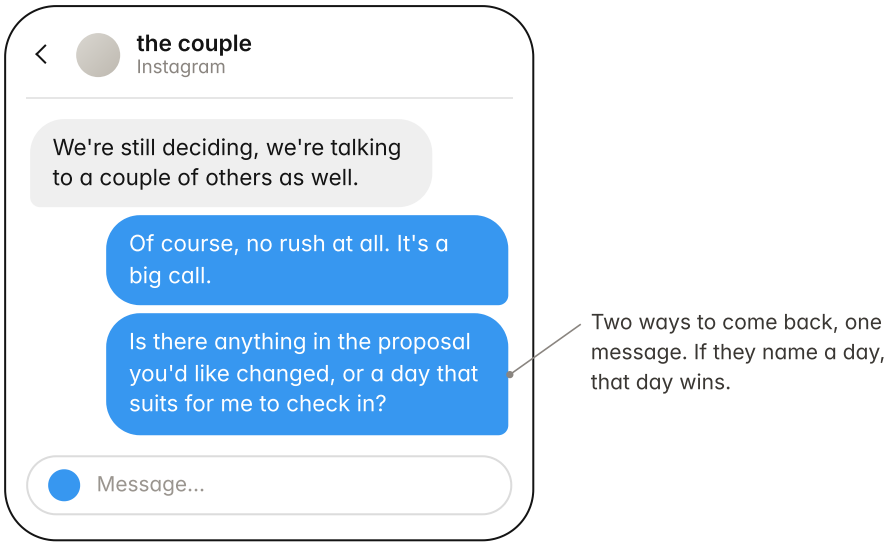
Give them the time, make it easy to come back, and be honest about the date.

Email

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Of course. It's a big decision and you should take the time you need.
>
> Two things that might help. First, if there's anything in the proposal you'd like changed, or anything you're not sure about, ask me. I'd rather fix it than have it sit there as a reason not to book. Second, [Wedding date] is still open with me as of today, but I don't hold dates without a booking, so if another couple asks about it I'll let you know straight away.
>
> Is there a day that suits you for me to check in? I'll put it in my diary and leave you alone until then.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

CONTENTS

DM



If they name a day, that day wins over every follow-up in your system. If they do not, the Follow-Up Vault takes over from here.

4. Partner wants someone else

"My partner likes another photographer's style." "We can't agree." "My fiancé wants to go with someone a friend used."

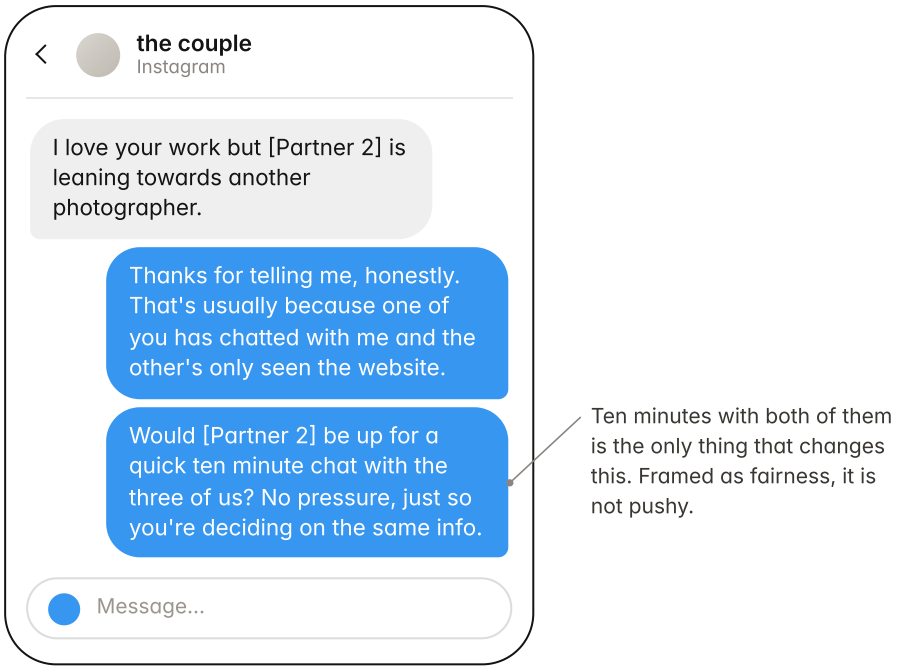
Do not argue with the partner you have not met. Get them both on a call, or get out of the way gracefully.

Email

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Thank you for being honest with me. This happens more than you'd think, and it's usually because one of you has had a 15 minute conversation with me and the other has only seen a website.
>
> If [Partner 2] is open to it, I'd love ten minutes with you both on a call. Not to talk anyone out of anything. Just so the decision is made with the same information on both sides. If after that the other photographer is the right fit, I'll be the first to say so.
>
> Would [two times] suit for a quick chat with you both?
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

CONTENTS

DM



If they say no to the call, close warmly and mean it. A couple who chooses someone else and feels respected sends you their friends.

> Completely understand. You should both love your photographer, and if that's [other photographer], you've chosen well. Have the most wonderful day, and if anything changes, you know where I am.

5. Fewer hours

"Can we just do five hours?" "We only need you for the ceremony and portraits." "What if we cut it down?"

Sometimes fewer hours is right and I say so. Sometimes it quietly breaks the photos they told me they wanted. Say which, and let them choose with the facts.

CONTENTS

Email, when fewer hours works

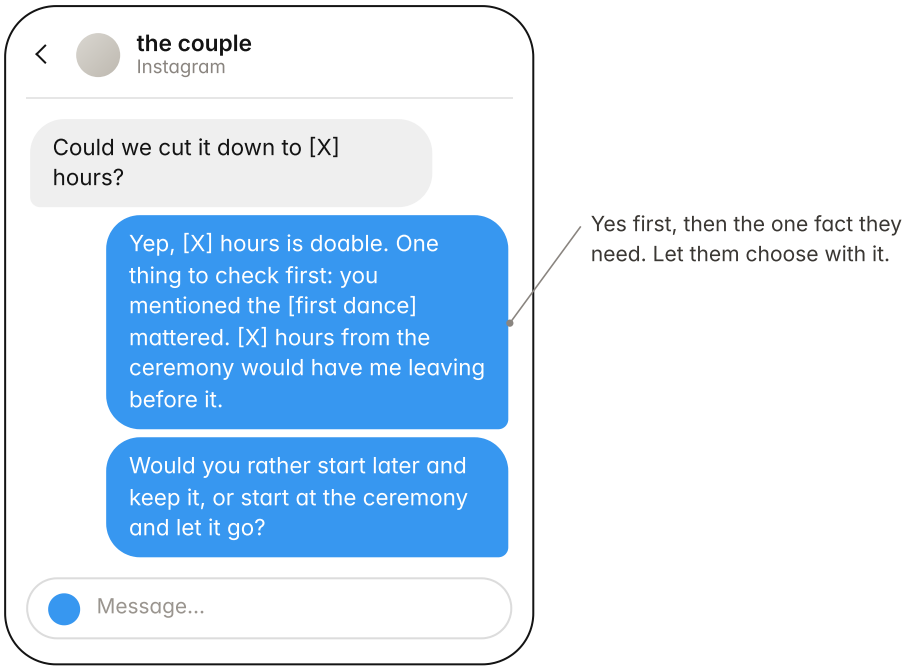
> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> Yes, that works. With the ceremony at [time] and portraits straight after, [X] hours covers everything you told me mattered.
>
> Here's what changes:
>
> - Coverage from [start] to [finish]
> - [What falls outside, for example "The getting ready and the end of the reception won't be covered"]
> - [New price, once]
>
> Everything else stays as we talked about. I'll send the revised proposal through tonight.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

Email, when fewer hours breaks what they wanted

> Hi [Partner 1] and [Partner 2],
>
> I can do [X] hours, and I want to be straight with you about what it changes.
>
> On the call you said [the thing they said mattered, for example "the first dance with your dad is the photo you most want on the wall"]. With [X] hours starting at the ceremony, I'd be packing up at [time], about [gap] before that happens.
>
> So two honest options:
>
> - ☑ hours from the ceremony, and we let the [first dance] go. [Price, once.]
> - ☑ hours starting later, from [time], so we keep the [first dance] and let the [getting ready] go instead. Same price.
>
> I'd lean towards the second, because of what you told me. But it's your day and your call, and either way I'll send the revised proposal tonight.
>
> Looking forward to hearing your thoughts.

CONTENTS

DM



Fewer hours is the one objection where the price genuinely drops, because they are buying less. The scope moves. The price per hour does not.

The two lines that run under all five

"I'd rather you only pay for what you need." Say it and mean it. It is the reason a couple trusts your price.

"It isn't held until it's booked." Say it once, calmly, every time. Honesty about the date is not pressure. Pretending the date is safe when it is not is the thing that costs you the booking.

CONTENTS

PART 5 OF 5

How to use this pack

One page. The order things fire in, and what to change for your own business.

The one rule

The first reply's only job is to book the call. Everything in this pack points at that. If you remember nothing else, remember that you are not trying to explain your photography in a DM or an email. You are trying to get 15 minutes.

The order things fire in

A couple messages you on Instagram

1. Check all three calendars if they gave a date.
2. First reply from Part 1. One detail mirrored, one question or the invite. No price, no link.
3. They say yes. Two times, then the booking link, then email and mobile.
4. They go quiet. One nudge inside 24 hours. After that, the Follow-Up Vault.
5. Log the lead by stage.

A couple fills in your enquiry form

1. The instant text goes out on its own.
2. Check all three calendars.
3. First reply from Part 2. Date first, one personal line, one question, the call link.
4. Set the two day to-do before you do anything else.
5. They book. The confirmation goes out on its own.
6. They go quiet. The Follow-Up Vault from day two.

After the call

1. The proposal email from Part 3, the same day, off your notes from the call.
2. If another couple wants the date, the competing enquiry paragraph goes under the investment line.
3. An objection comes back. Part 4.
4. They go quiet. The Follow-Up Vault, proposal track.

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5. Contract signed and retainer paid. The welcome email. Only then is the date booked.

What to change for your business

Go through these once, write your answers down, and the pack is yours.

DECIDE	WHERE IT LANDS
Your one sentence reason for not pricing in chat. Mine is that I have no set packages. If you have packages, write yours	Part 1, the habits, and every price pushback script
Your three calendars	Part 1 and Part 2, the date check
What you call the call, and how long it runs. I say "a quick 15 minute chat"	Everywhere
Your starting figure, used only on a direct ask and never tied to hours	Part 1 second push, Part 2 third first reply
Your referral photographer for dates you cannot take, and one honest line on why you trust them	Part 1 and Part 2, date taken
Your planning resource, the one free useful thing you give couples	Part 2 placeholders, and the Follow-Up Vault
Your retainer terms, and whether you offer instalments	Part 2 and Part 3
Your real gallery turnaround plus a buffer, turned into exact dates per couple	Part 3
Your three beliefs about how you work, in words a couple would say back to you	Part 3, the proposal page
Your stance on discounting, in your own words, before anyone asks	Part 4
Where you track leads and the stage names you will use	Part 1 tracking, Part 2 pipeline

How to make a script sound like you

1. Read it out loud. Anywhere you stumble is a line you would not say. Change it.
2. Swap my words for yours in the "words I have swapped" table. Keep the shape, lose the phrasing.
3. Write one real sentence for every PERSONAL line, every time. That sentence is the product. The template is the packaging.
4. Never send the same follow-up wording twice to the same couple.
5. After a month, keep the lines that got replies and cut the ones that did not. Your version will be better than mine, because it is yours.

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What this pack does not do

It does not write your follow-ups after a couple goes quiet. That is the Follow-Up Vault, by day and channel. It does not run your call. That is the Consult Call Kit. It does not set your prices. Nothing here tells you what to charge, and nothing should.

If you bought this pack and later join the full program, you will not pay for these scripts twice. They are the foundation of two of its modules, and buyers of this pack are credited or upgraded, never charged again for the same material.
